

TRAINING KEY LEADERS FOR THE 21ST CENTURY CHURCH

* Blue denotes power point slide

*Brown denotes instructions to technician

WALKING THE FENCE

Recently an elderly minister friend related a story to me out of his past ministry experience and I would like to share it with you along with what I believe to be a very practical application for life and ministry in the 21st Century.

Many years ago my friend spent several years in Scotland doing missions work. During this time he became personally acquainted with many people who made their living as shepherds. One day he was helping a shepherd friend tend to the needs of his flock and the shepherd realized one of

his ewes, who was expected to calve any day, was missing. In an effort to find the missing ewe the shepherd asked the minister to “*Walk the Fence*” because the shepherd had not done so for a couple of days.

Walking the fence is a normal part of shepherding. Walking the fence is something that is done at least several times a week. When a Shepherd walks the fence he does so with several things in mind:

(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- He is attempting to discover whether the fence has been breached...
- He is looking to see if anything has entered or exited the property that would not be in the best interest of the sheep...
- He is looking for hazards that might be detrimental to the sheep... (i.e. A fence which is down; a loose fence post; a sagging wire; a wire which has been left loose and might get caught in the wool of the sheep; etc)

- He is making sure everything inside the fence and in close proximity to the fence, in no way poses a danger to his flock...

Walking the fence might seem at times to be an insignificant part of shepherding, but in reality it can mean the difference between success and failure for the shepherd, and it could very well be the difference between life and death for the sheep.

On this particular day, my friend began his journey around the fence, and before long he found the ewe and her newborn lamb, both dead, inside the fence. The ewe had ventured too closely to the barbed wire fence, which had been repaired a few weeks earlier. The person who had made the repairs had failed to cut off a small piece of excess wire just a few inches in length, and the ewe became entrapped when the barbed wire buried itself in her coat of wool. To no

avail, the ewe had obviously attempted to free herself from the barbed wire. Because of the physical exhaustion of attempting to free her-self, she had no strength left, and died during the calving process. Not only did she perish but her little lamb died as well!

As church leaders we must be constantly walking the fence, checking on the ones with which God has entrusted us! We cannot afford for the sheep or lambs we are watching over for the good shepherd to perish on our watch! Shepherding is serious business. As under-shepherds, we will eventually be called upon to give an account for everyone God has placed in our care!

What does walking the fence look like for 21st century church leader? (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- We walk the fence by routinely praying for the people who have been entrusted

to us... Many times God will reveal certain things about certain people as we intercede for them.

- We walk the fence by interacting with the people... It is very difficult to shepherd people we never interact with. As we interact with them we often see warning signs of things that should not be in their lives.
- We walk the fence by paying attention to who they are hanging out with... Someone said “*You can tell a lot about a person by looking at who their friends are!*”
- We walk the fence by noticing their habit of church attendance... A pattern of declining church attendance is always a warning sign that something is just not right.
- We walk the fence by noticing changes in giving patterns... When a person decides to attend a church, the last thing to come with them is their money,

because they must first buy into the vision of the house. The first thing to go when a person leaves a church is their money!

As church leaders we have been given the wonderful privilege of oversight of the flock of God. We need to get our hiking boots on and not fail to walk the fence!

No pastor can walk the fence alone. The responsibility of the key leaders is to assist the pastor in noticing what is going on in the lives of people and taking the appropriate action.

Summary:

The following things must be kept at the forefront for pastors and lay leaders:

(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The work of key leaders is caring for the people...

- Prayer and the ministry of the word are very important but there is much more to shepherding...
- Much effort must be invested into being close enough to the people that changes in behavior speak to the leader and an appropriate action can be taken...
- The pastor needs a team of people who are constantly walking the fence for the good of the people...

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EFFECTIVE CHURCHES

Listen to what happened when the New Testament Church got the structure right. Acts 6:7 (NIV) ***“So the word of God spread. The number of disciples in Jerusalem increased rapidly, and a large number of priests became obedient to the faith.”***

God uses all kinds of churches: big ones, little ones, and medium sized ones. It is no more wrong for a church to be small than for a church to be large.

In ministry I have learned there are actually two unpardonable sins: failure and success.

One seems to be as unforgiveable as the other.

What most of our peers are looking for and wanting from us is mediocrity. If we allow ourselves to stay confined to the mediocre, we can find acceptance because it makes everyone else feel more comfortable. What is the driving force behind this? Jealousy! The problem is that we are constantly comparing ourselves with one another and we have been warned in the Word not to do such a thing.

While there is nothing wrong with a church being small, there is something wrong with a church allowing its mentality and congregation to accept its smallness.
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

I realize that there is a glass ceiling in every community, but I am convinced most

churches have never even been close enough to that ceiling to see it. The excuse for a church remaining small is often “*We are just in a small community and we are doing what we can.*” Really?

- How long has it been since every door in the community has been knocked?
- How long has it been since every home in the community has received some kind of information about the church?
- Does every person in the community know what the church is all about?
- Do we know what the people in our community would be looking for if they decided to attend church?

I dare say [most churches stay small for a reason.](#)

I am fully aware [the proper measure of success for a church is how many it sends, not how many it keeps.](#) The problem is, many churches are not doing either.

We actually have churches that do not report one conversion in a year. Not only are they not seeing people saved, they give nothing to missions. This means the pastor is not winning souls or giving anything to missions either! “*Monkey see, monkey do!*”

The first-century church found a paradigm that would work. They empowered the pastor and staff and then gave them qualified lay people who could lead a ministry without constant supervision. The role of the minister then would be to:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Pray...
- Prepare...
- Cast vision...
- Train...
- Delegate...

What was the end result? ***“The word of God spread. The number of disciples in Jerusalem increased rapidly, and a large number of priests became obedient to the faith.”***

So we must ask ourselves, do we want to be a part of an effective church? If so we must:

- Properly manage conflict... (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)
- Give the pastor the best available leaders to work with...
- Give the pastor leaders who are compatible with his personality and ministry style...
- Release the pastor/staff to lead the church...
- Get ready, get ready, get ready...

Summary:

The following is a list of practical things a successful pastor/staff led church must do:
(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The pastor/staff must be empowered to lead...
- The pastor/staff must conceive and develop a God vision for the church...
- The pastor/staff must effectively communicate the vision to the people...
(Suggestion: Conduct a family meeting at least once a year on a Sunday morning – A family meeting is where the pastor casts vision for the year and conducts a questions and answer session at the conclusion of the meeting)
- The pastor/staff must effectively communicate decisions to the people...
- The pastor must conduct key leader meetings regularly to keep the key leaders on the same page...
- Key leaders should attend as many meetings as possible...
- The key leader agenda should be closed and the pastor should comply with this as well...

- The agenda should be sent to the key leaders at least one week prior to the meeting...
- Caucusing about agenda items should never be allowed...

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GRWOTH BARRIERS

If one studies church growth, it soon becomes apparent that there are common obstacles to growing healthy, vibrant churches. Let's look at a few of them.

Failure to create a culture of invitation (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) Most pastors and church leaders desire church growth but fail to know how to create a culture of invitation. We pray, we motivate, we emphasize...but members still don't invite their friends to church. Why is this?

First of all, most churches fail to create a culture of invitation. If the church is going to grow, there must be a culture of invitation woven into the DNA of the church. There are many ways to accomplish this, but I would like to give you a personal experience. In January of 2009, I started preaching a series of sermons on our responsibility for inviting the unchurched. The statistics say that 85% of the unchurched would attend a service if they were to be invited.

I bought an old time attendance register and placed it on a tripod on the stage and placed a cover over it. When I got up to preach I unveiled the attendance register and on it I had placed:

- Invited this week...
- Invited last week...
- Saved this week...
- Saved last week...

Sure enough, no one had been invited to come to church and no one accepted Christ. I placed zeroes on the board and left it for all to see as I preached my sermon.

The next Sunday the same thing happened, except now we had four zeroes on the board. We were the zero church. This went on for weeks until the people finally realized I was going to do this until they started inviting people. After a while hundreds were being invited and dozens per week were coming to Christ. I continued this for more than six months. Creating a culture of invitation is not easy, but it is doable. If a church is to grow, a culture of invitation is non-negotiable.

Sometimes the truth is, they're embarrassed to invite anyone. The Sunday service must be the main event. It doesn't have to be perfect, but it has to be the best we can make it. The sermon should be well thought out

from the opening remarks to how the altar service will be conducted. The music must be very good and plenty of rehearsal time should be the norm.

When we try to create a culture of invitation, we will only be successful if the service is something our people would not be ashamed to invite their friends to.

Fearing growth will change the church
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT
SLIDE)

Even though members and attenders may not say this, some of them will subtly fight growth because they fear that when the congregation gets larger, they won't know everyone. They also fear that the changes necessary to grow the church will somehow keep the church from meeting their needs.

The key is that as the church grows larger, it must grow smaller at the same time. I know

that sounds crazy, but let me explain. One of the most appealing things about church is that it is a place where one can grow healthy, long-term relationships. It is true – the larger a church grows, the more challenging this becomes. Therefore, the answer to this problem is to find a way to get everyone into small groups. The Sunday worship service becomes the large gathering and the small groups are where the intimate relationships are developed. This is certainly not an easy thing to do, but it is possible with a little thought and reasearch and a lot of hard work.

Being too traditional to transition
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT
SLIDE)

Believe it or not, the basis for tradition is success. A tradition is developed because at some point it was “*The Thing*” and worked very effectively. Is it not true that when

something works, we repeat it over and over again?

Unfortunately, most things that work are seasonal. They work for a season, and as the circumstances change, they are no longer as effective or they don't work at all.

The church is notorious for holding to traditions that haven't worked in decades. The problem is that we have a tendency to make a tradition sacred, and when we do we cannot transition because our tradition has become a holy thing.

Growing churches are constantly evaluating everything they do. When a program or ministry has run its course, they retire the tradition and roll something newer and more effective out in its place.

In growing churches, the process of evaluation is always driven by the questions:

- Is this effective?

- Why are we doing this?
- Is there a more effective way to accomplish our goals?

Failure to identify a target audience
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

As much as we would like to, we cannot appeal to everyone. If a local radio station played a classical song, followed by a country western song, followed by a rock song, followed by a rap song, who do you think their audience would be? Everyone? No one?

Radio stations find a niche because they understand people are attracted by different styles.

The church is trying to out Hollywood... Hollywood! We seem to think we can attract the crowd by our well oiled programs and productions. The truth is we are trying to

compete with the world, rather than to reach the world.

Each church leadership team must decide who God is calling them to reach, and go after that demographic. When we decide to go after a certain demographic, we must tailor our style to attract our target audience. This must be done without kicking the Holy Spirit or His gifts to the curb.

Never forget, the Holy Spirit will not remain at a church that treats Him like a crazy cousin that no one wants to talk about. He will not be confined to a backroom or a special service. No matter what the demographic is that you are targeting, the Holy Spirit must be front and center in all that we do.

Failure to value process above programs
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

Most plateaued and declining churches have one thing in common. They believe their programs are going to keep people and grow the church. The fact is, programs do not grow the church, processes grow the church.

For instance if our vision is to reach, teach and send, we cannot accomplish this with programming. If we are to be successful in reaching the stated goals, we must establish an outreach that engages our members in reaching out to the unchurched. We must also establish small groups that are effective in discipling people into mature believers. Then we must have a launching mechanism that sends the disciples out to connect with the unchurched.

The healthy, vibrant, growing church gets this, and they not only develop a process to bring the vision to a reality, they also constantly evaluate all processes.

Allowing meetings to trump ministry
(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT
SLIDE)

I think we can all agree that you cannot judge a church by how many it keeps, but by how many it sends. If this is true, why are we so number conscious? Most churches have one measurement of success – numbers. Whether it is attendance numbers at our meetings or budget numbers, this seems to be the scorecard being used most frequently.

Is God interested in numbers? He named a book in His Bible Numbers! Numbers are important, but when this is the only measurement of success, we quickly begin producing passive spectators who are difficult to motivate beyond attending a meeting to get their nose counted.

What we are trying to produce are disciples. One day when I was praying, the Lord gave

me the following definition of what it means to make a disciple. *“You have not made a disciple until you have reached and trained an individual, and they have reached someone and are in the process of discipling that individual.”*

- The Profit:
- People...
- Processes...
- Product...

Numbers will not guarantee discipleship, but proper processes will.

Lack of trust among leaders

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

One of the most significant deterrents to church growth is lack of trust. If the top level leaders do not trust each other, nothing else is going to work right.

When key leaders do not trust each other, it will always follow that the congregation will find it difficult to trust the leaders. This is because a lack of trust among key leaders always causes infighting, and eventually the congregation is brought into the disagreement and the church starts to implode from the inside.

The vision the pastor is casting in the church must be followed and implemented by the key leaders. If a key leader cannot agree with the direction of the pastor, they should do what they can to resolve the issue. If it cannot be resolved, they should quietly remove themselves from the leadership team.

Church leaders should always bear in mind that the end result of a lack of trust is a church fight. Every church fight will bring with it casualties. I have never seen a church fight that did not end with some people

leaving the church never to return to any church.

This should be a consideration before we decide to allow our staunch position to allow us to draw the battle lines. Churches decline and die when they allow their lack of trust to disintegrate into infighting.

Control issues

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

Church politics strangles the life out of most churches. Many times the pecking order has been long established and change comes slowly and painfully if at all.

The problem with unhealthy control in a church is that it is almost always slanted toward some power brokers. God never intended His church to operate in this manner. The church is supposed to be a theocracy not a democracy.

It is true there should be collaboration along the way, but according to the Word of God the following model develops into a healthy church: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Christ is the head of the church...
- The pastor is the undershepherd...
- The key leaders are chosen to serve the pastor and his vision...
- The key leaders are trained by the pastor to do the work of the ministry...

Control issues should never exist in the church; the Word of God gave us the model for building an effective church and we should be diligent to follow it implicitly.

Summary:

If we are to remove the barriers to church growth we must: (PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Find a way to create a culture of invitation...
- Discover ways of growing smaller while growing larger...
- Be aware of what has run its course and replace it with something that works in today's world...
- Know the demographics of who you are attempting to reach and develop a strategy that works with your target audience...
- Set well defined processes in place for everything you are attempting to accomplish...
- Ministry rather than meetings must be the goal...
- Foster a culture of trust...
- All power brokers must take a step back or be dealt with...

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TIPPING POINTS

The phrase tipping point means: (PLACE
ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- The moment of critical mass...
- The boiling point...
- The moment when something unique becomes common...
- The dramatic moment in an organization when everything changes at once...

If we take a moment or two, we can all think of tipping points along the pathway of life:

- Conversion...
- Graduation...
- Marriage...

- Buying a home...
- Having a baby...
- Facing health issues...
- Retirement...

A church reaches tipping points as well. Sadly, some tipping points are detrimental while many are high water marks in the life of the church. (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) We have all lived through a plethora of both.

Healthy change is normally preceded with grueling, sometimes exhausting incremental steps of thought and action, but the fact remains that tipping points occur in one dramatic moment. We must be sensitive to the timing and the people among whom we minister, but we must also be aware when a tipping point is at hand. This is called context. When a tipping point transpires the expectation level rises.

The thing about a tipping point in a church is that the expectation level of the body changes in one critical moment. (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

The old adage is that when the tide rises, the level of all the boats in the harbor changes.

When an organization achieves a level of success with an event or the spiritual mood reaches a crescendo, everything we do from that day forward is judged against the backdrop of the success of that moment, as it should be.

In thinking through our many years of ministry at CT Church, there have been many tipping points:

- The first Easter outreach...
- The first Health Fair...
- Confronting a bully serving on the Board...
- Planting churches...

- Opening additional campuses and venues...
- Take the Plunge Sunday...
- Red Bandana Sunday...
- Managing seven Sunday morning services in four locations...

I could go on, but you get the idea that when we reach these critical tipping points, there is usually no going back whether we are headed in a good or bad direction.

If our attitude becomes “*Then we need to be careful about how high we raise the bar because we will paint ourselves into a corner*” we need to: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Get alone with God for a faith lift...
- Embark on a plan of personal improvement...
- Decide to stop impeding the progress of the team...

At every tipping point the expectation level increases for every team member. Because of this, some team members are only on the team for a season; others remain throughout the entire journey.

The responsibility level rises. When a tipping point occurs within the context of the church, everyone on the leadership team must assume new responsibilities.

If I ever backslide, it will be while driving. The most annoying people on the earth have a steering wheel in their hands! Slow traffic should always keep right! Slow drivers in the left lane are inconsiderate, inexcusable and downright annoying. I have a disdain for people who drive slow in the left lane.

As a member of the leadership team of a church that is rapidly transitioning from tipping point to tipping point, **every member of the team will have to decide whether they**

are going to impede traffic or accelerate
their serve to help set the pace. (LEAVE ON
SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

As the church cycles through tipping points
the level of responsibility becomes greater
for all leaders at all levels. This finds its
expression in:

- Loyalty...
- Faithfulness...
- Productivity...

Team members must always bear in mind
that persuasion occurs in ways we do not
understand or appreciate. (LEAVE ON THE
SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

As leaders, we have a responsibility to make
sure our loyalty, faithfulness and
productivity is creating an opportunity for
the team to reach another tipping point.

By our influence, we draw others into our
rhythms by our attitudes and interaction.

The people will respond to change in the same way team members embrace it.

Are we living up to our responsibility of being a team member of a church transitioning through a series of tipping points?

This church will never be stronger than the weakest link of the leadership team. We have to ask ourselves – are we pulling our weight or are we impeding the progress of the team because we can't stand the pull?

The impact level rises. The really interesting thing about tipping points is that in the beginning, the progress realized from tipping points is minuet, almost immeasurable. As the organization passes the mileposts of one tipping point after another, the impact becomes more and more measureable.

Finally one discovers the tipping points are extremely significant because yesterday's ceiling is today's floor. (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) The trajectory of the organization can be charted on a graph where there are few plateaus or downturns, and the trip becomes one gradual climb.

In such a scenario, each team member MUST realize that any deviation from 100% effort or uniformity can result in a loss of impact and the growth of the organization is adversely affected. Loss of momentum is the death rattle of the organization. Think of this:

- A bad report from ten spies kept each of the ten out of the Promised Land for a lifetime...
- A bad report from ten spies kept an entire generation out of the Promised Land forever...

- A bad report from ten spies kept their own families out of the Promised Land for more than forty years...
- A bad report from ten spies kept two men of faith from the Promised Land for more than forty years...

The loss of impact in this scenario is significant. The last thing we want or need is a loss of impact.

Small actions can have momentous effects.
(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) The truth is that small things matter as much as big things. In golf it means nothing to be able to drive the ball three hundred yards if ones chipping and putting are a disaster.

A church leadership team must always be on a quest to find new ways to create tipping points. With the help of the Holy Spirit and the creativity of a team, tipping points can

become more significant and more frequent as the team moves forward.

A team working together in harmony produces a synergy that creates a culture of maximum impact. (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE) Leviticus 26:8 (NKJV) ***“Five of you shall chase a hundred, and a hundred of you shall put ten thousand to flight; your enemies shall fall by the sword before you.”*** If one extrapolates the effect created by ***“Five chasing a hundred”*** it stands to reason that one hundred can chase two thousand. Yet the Bible says ***“A hundred of you can put ten thousand to flight!”***

Because of the synergy of a team, the ability of a person to produce rises from a ratio of one-to-twenty to one-to-one hundred!

A culture of tipping points can be created by: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Evaluating everything...
- Stopping the things that are not working...
- Making improvements to the things that are working...
- Making changes sooner rather than later...
- Always keeping the objective of the team at the forefront of everything...

Summary:

If a team is attempting to create tipping points, they should be asking the following questions on a regular basis: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Have we missed a tipping point? Why?
- Are we currently at a tipping point?
- How can we create a tipping point?

- How can we maximize the moment of the next tipping point?